to have a fairly lenient lockdown, like many other countries, it would not have been as bold a decision. However, we didn't know how long the virus would circulate amongst us, we didn't have proven treatments available, we didn't have enough equipment to safeguard even our healthcare professionals, we didn't have a vaccine in sight and didn't even have the required infrastructure should the virus spread unchecked in our very dense society. In this situation, the prime minister made a strategic decision to impose a stringent lockdown, later rated as the most stringent lockdown in the world by an Oxford University survey.[26] Had we opted for a more moderate strategy, we would have had to be prepared for very negative outcomes. In India's case, the worst outcomes were widely believed to be mass starvation and deaths following the disruption of supply chains and mass bankruptcy.

Let's consider this extreme event of national lockdown as one side of the barbell. In order to balance the barbell on the other side of the connecting line, i.e., when we emerged out of our lockdown, aggressive pumping in of resources would have to be undertaken by the government depending on feedback on how our businesses responded. Speaking on India's economic recovery strategy, Sanjeev Sanyal, principal economic advisor to the GoI, noted,

> This (barbell) approach is often seen as one lacking a grand plan, and this is positively true. However, when dealing in uncertainty—it is impossible to have a grand, prescribed plan. It is only viable to have a broad mission and a broad vision and moving forward based on the feedback loop. It is reactive, yes. But what it does allow you to do, is to feel your way across the river by feeling the strokes. Incidentally, China itself used this approach to build itself up to becoming the world's second largest economy in just three decades.[27]

In a way, fears of mass food shortages were allayed as the government managed to provide substantial rations, free LPG cylinders and cash transfers. While relief measures totalled to only about 1.1 per cent of our GDP, states were allowed to increase their borrowing limit to 3 per cent of their gross state domestic product (GSDP), out of which 0.5 per cent would be unconditional. The remaining amount would be conditional to the implementation of Centre-recommended policy reforms. However, these